

In search of inspiration...



Jayesh Shinde
Technical Editor –
Test Centre
jayesh.shinde@digit.in

"If I'm in Digit today writing about technology, it's thanks to the mark technology left on me early on in life, and that through it we can achieve the unimaginable. All this wouldn't have been possible without the doyens of the technology world."

When I was growing up, I had interests in a variety of things. Sports, music, and space exploration, in particular, were especially close to my heart. From cricket to football and tennis, listening to classical Hindi movie songs, watching early cable TV science shows on space exploration and other heavenly bodies. I was awestruck by some of the sporting greats of my generation that I followed on the tele – from Sachin Tendulkar to Michael Jordan (oh those early Monday morning NBA telecasts before running to catch the school bus), Tiger Woods to Pete Sampras, Bhaichung Bhutia to Zinedine Zidane. And I tried to emulate them on the pitch to the best of my abilities. It was the same while trying to sing like Kishore Kumar or staying awake at nights in our native village just to gaze at the stars as they floated across the sky, wondering why Neil Armstrong or NASA couldn't go beyond the moon to more unexplored worlds.

With the sobering effect of age, the eyes don't glitter as brightly as they used to, but such topics still excite me to this day. No doubt that by themselves each of these interest areas are fascinating enough to entice enamoured eyes to explore them in greater depth. But that doesn't take away the importance of having iconic figures associated with these areas who could inspire the next generation to follow in their footsteps, and perhaps even go further, achieving more than their childhood icons ever could.

As my interest in technology began and grew, guys like Bill Gates, Steve Jobs and Linus Torvalds fascinated me. Just the sheer skill of starting their own tech companies or movement to challenge the established order and successfully realise their vision through technology is immensely inspirational. When I used Microsoft Windows, played with an Apple product, or tried my hand at Linux, I was constantly reminded of these tech pioneers who left an indelible mark on the world of technology. If I'm in Digit today writing about technology, it's thanks to the mark technology left on me early on in life, and that through it we can achieve the unimaginable. All this wouldn't have been possible without the doyens of the technology world.

Today, I observe a lot of us here in India taking pride and happiness out of the achievements of guys such as Shantanu Narayen, Sundar Pichai and Satya Nadella, who are CEOs of Adobe, Google and Microsoft, respectively. I beg to differ with that popular sentiment. Let me explain.

I don't want to take anything away from the professional heights that Shantanu Narayen, Sundar Pichai and Satya Nadella have reached in their respective careers, but I still think they're working for enterprises erected by far superior individuals – something that they'd readily accept themselves. In their current capacity, they're nothing but glorified suits. And they're far away from home to have any significant impact on young, impressionable minds who are presumably looking up to them for inspiration.

The world of technology desperately needs new outliers to emerge and save the world from the increasing commoditisation of technology. More so in India now than ever before.

Don't get me wrong, I'm not saying there haven't been stalwarts from our nation that we can't look up to. The most recent one I can think of is Dr APJ Abdul Kalam and further back in time you have CV Raman, Narinder Singh Kapany, Dr Homi Bhabha and Satyendra Nath Bose. Other than these luminaries, I can't seem to recall anyone in India who can be considered an inspiration in the field of science and technology. With our fast-exploding startup scene, there's hope that we will have new inspirations to look up to. But we need those stars to emerge fast over what appears to be an increasingly darkening horizon of innovation and guide us towards the promise of a new brighter tomorrow made possible with the help of technology. 🇮🇳

Let me know your thoughts on this column at: facebook.com/jayesh.shinde / [@jshinde](https://twitter.com/jshinde) / jayesh.shinde@digit.in